# Introduction

'Gender' is a verb that is best understood, simultaneously and uneasily, as both transitive and reflexive: others gender me, and I gender myself. Along with the visual presentation of one's body, the sound of one's voice is among the most strongly gendered aspects of behavior. Transgender people[1] know this intimately, as our speech is highly scrutinized by those who – consciously or unconsciously – seek to enforce the gender binary (Jessee and Calder 2025). In this thesis, I investigate how this knowledge manifests by comparing English-speaking transfeminine[2] speakers' linguistic behavior across two conversational contexts: a conversation with a cisgender[3] woman, and a conversation with a trans woman. I focus on their pronunciation of the /s/ sound (the first sound in 'safe' and the last sound in 'face'), a well-studied site of gendered linguistic variation.

It has become widely accepted both in the academic study of gender and parts of the popular consciousness that gender is performative (Butler 1990; Henry and Hall 2025). Most simply, this means that gender does not exist outside of cultural and historical context, and is constantly constructed and reconstructed by social behavior. Under this view, scholars of gender develop their models by studying the behaviors involved in gender, and how those behaviors come to have gendering effects. Language is of primary importance to the construction of gender; speech about gender is arguably the foundation of gender's existence. For instance, the speech of medical specialists conducting an ultrasound or delivering a newborn – "it's a girl!" or "it's a boy!", or the imperatives "act ladylike" and "man up", do the performative work of enforcing and solidifying gender.

Yet, talk about gender does not represent the beginning and end of the linguistic performativity of gender. Sociolinguistics, the study of language and the social world, recognizes that variations in language use beyond the referential – less "what one says", more "how one says it" – are socially meaningful and performative (Henry and Hall 2025). The common belief that one's gender can be

[1] I use 'transgender' or 'trans' to refer to those who identify with this label. Many transgender people understand the term broadly to include all who do not fully identify with the gender assigned to them at birth. However, the term is sometimes narrowed to refer mostly to transgender men and transgender women, who primarily identify with the opposite binary gender of the gender assigned to them at birth.

[2] I use the term 'transfeminine' to refer to thsoe who identify with this label, primarily trans women and feminine nonbinary people (especially those assigned male at birth, for whom transition is a move towards a feminine identity).

[3] I use 'cisgender' or 'cis' to refer to people who are not transgender.

guessed or determined from the sound of their voice attests to the importance of the sound of the voice in the construction and performance of gender. For example, if a perciever hears a voice that is higher pitched, they may assume the speaker is a woman, whereas if it is lower pitched, they may assume the speaker is a man. Here, the perciever construes high pitch to be a sign of femininity, and low pitch to be a sign of masculinity. Associations like these are known in sociolinguistics as 'indexical', as the relationship is imagined to be causal or co-occurent, much like the indexical link between smoke and fire.

It bears emphasis that the process of interpreting variations in language use (such as variations in voice pitch) as meaningful signs depends on perceivers' understanding of the world (Gal and Irvine 2019). Some indexicalities, such as the indexical link between voice pitch and gender, are the products of understandings of the world which align with and support structures of power (Calder 2021). These indexicalities come to be entrenched as expectations and norms, benefitting those who fit into gendered ideals and marginalizing those who do not. Although many cultures have somewhat overlapping gender ideals, including the idealization of the feminine voice as higher-pitched and the masculine voice as lower-pitched, the character of these indexicalities and their applications is nonetheless culturally specific. In the western, English-speaking, North American cultural context of this study, gendered indexicalities such as this one are embedded in an understanding of gender which idealizes those in power and privilege here: white, cisgender, heterosexual, middle-class men and women. These norms serve to marginalize those outside of this group, deeming their language use inadequate and inappropriate (eg. Inoue 2006; Inoue 2003; Flores and Rosa 2015; Heffernan 2023).

In investigating indexicality, existing sociolinguistic studies primarily focus on only one set of these expectations, either the normative, powerful set described above (eg. Hazenberg 2012; Podesva and Van Hofwegen 2015) and henceforth referred to as 'hegemonic', or alternative, local sets constructed within marginalized communities (eg. Mendoza 2024; Calder 2019a). Within the realm of the study of trans speech, the former type of study often interprets trans voices in their deviance from or compliance with cisnormativity, and runs the risk of tacitly enforcing hegemonic norms, marginalizing the diversity of trans voices (Calder and A. Steele 2025). Furthermore, focus within a single interpretive lens – hegemonic or otherwise – often sidelines the intersubjective nature of identity, by which identity emerges in the interaction of subjects and their establishment of contrast between self and other, speaker and listener (Bucholtz and Hall 2010). Marginalized speakers hold awareness both of hegemonic and alternative indexicalities, and must be aware of how their listener will interpret their speech.

Recent research has worked to take up this perspective, placing more even focus on both sides of the speaker-listener pair by investigating how trans voices are perceived by listeners (Jessee and Calder 2025) and trans people's understandings of these perceptions (Heffernan 2023). However, prior research has not investigated how these understandings manifest in trans speakers' actual linguistic practice. A mainstay of sociolinguistics is the study of changes within individual speakers' language use in response to changes in context, known as style-shifting. Many

of these studies investigate how speakers change their speech depending on their listener, finding listener or audience to be a primary motivating factor for shifts (e.g. Podesva 2007; Rickford and Mcnair-Knox 1994). A study of this sort on trans speakers, treating the listener as a variable, has not yet been conducted. By filling this gap, I provide data on how transfeminine speakers navigate cisgender linguistic norms.

Language and gender research has found that, similar to voice pitch, the English /s/ sound varies in pronunciation, and that hegemonic gender norms expect men and women to pronounce /s/ differently. I focus on this sound for two primary reasons. First, unlike voice pitch, gendered variation in /s/ is not influenced by gendered anatomy; voice pitch is influenced by the size of the vocal tract, whereas /s/ pronunciation is not (Zimman 2017c). Second, research has found that when men pronounce /s/ differently than norms expect them to, their voices are percieved as sounding gay (e.g. Calder 2019a). For transfeminine speakers, this makes /s/ particularly difficult territory, as moving toward feminine /s/ pronunciations may only result in being mispercieved as gay men. In order to study how trans speakers navigate hegemonic linguistic norms, I look to this most difficult situation, investigating how transfeminine speakers shift /s/ pronunciations from a conversation with a transgender listener to one with a cisgender listener, and what factors may influence the (likely unconscious) decision to shift.

There are three possible outcome behaviors: speakers shift towards more hegemonically feminine /s/ pronunciations with the cis listener, speakers do not shift, or speakers shift away from hegemonically feminine /s/ pronunciations with the cis listener. In the first case, I predict that speakers who are unconcerned with being mistaken for gay men but who do wish to avoid being judged as insufficiently feminine by cis listeners are most likely to shift towards more hegemonically feminine /s/ pronunciations with the cis listener. The other two outcomes (either no shift or a shift away from hegemonically feminine /s/ pronunciations with the cisgender listener) would be most likely for speakers who differ from this description: those who are concerned with being mistaken for gay men, those who are unconcerned with cisgender judgements.

In order to test these predictions, I recruited 4 transfeminine speakers and 2 women conversation partners, one trans and one cis. I conducted 20-30 minute one-on-one audio recorded casual conversation sessions between each speaker and each conversation partner in which participants were asked to collaboratively play a word game and then to chat casually and get to know each other. I then acoustically measured their /s/ pronunciations in each recording. After the conversation sessions, I interviewed each speaker, asking questions about their relationship with gender, sexuality, and their voice, with a focus on the challenges of dealing with cisgender perceptions, and assessed the extent to which speakers expressed the concerns and goals pertaining to my predictions.

I find that two speakers shift towards more hegemonically feminine /s/ pronunciations with the cisgender listener, one speaker does not shift, and one speaker shifts away from hegemonically feminine /s/ pronunciations with the cisgender listener. Counter to my predictions, the former two speakers (who shifted towards

more hegemonically feminine /s/ pronunciations) were the two who expressed concern about sounding like gay men and who otherwise seemed most unconcerned with cisgender judgements. Also counter to my prediction, the latter two speakers (who did not shift towards more hegemonically feminine /s/ pronunciations with the cisgender listener) seemed concerned with cisgender judgements and did not mention concerns about sounding like gay men.

These mismatches between my predictions and the outcomes lead me to two additional conclusions. First, regardless of speakers' intentions, it is likely that speakers differ in the extent to which they (unconsciously or consciously) pick up on /s/ norms and learn to vary their /s/ pronunciations. In this way, it might be said that shifting is less accessible to some speakers than others. For trans people, this may develop and change over the course of transition; the speaker who did not shift her /s/ pronunciations was also at an earlier stage of her transition than other speakers. Additionally, trans people's experiences with voice dysphoria, the feeling that their voice does not sound the way they would like it to sound, attest to this issue of accessibility. Second, it seems that the causal order may be the reverse of my prediction with respect to misrecognition. Rather than concern with sounding like gay men causing speakers not to shift towards hegemonically feminine /s/, it seems possible that shifting towards hegemonically feminine /s/ causes speakers to be misrecognized as gay men.

These conclusions emphasize the difficulty of trans speakers' linguistic position and the injustice of hegemonic norms; in both cases, trans speakers' success in being properly percieved by cisgender speakers is limited. Trans liberation therefore cannot simply involve trans people 'improving' in their adherence to gender norms which will always exclude us, but rather must consist of the deconstruction of these norms altogether.